



ISHAN TANKHA

ADOPTION

Sohna | HARYANA



Home, not alone

A birth family doesn't always mean a home. Adoptions are rising in urban India, as is their acceptance.

■ By Purvi Malhotra

A dusty, splintered road cramped with two-way traffic heading towards Sohna in Haryana, also leads to the El Deco Mansionz, where symmetrical red-brick houses overlook small, cosy gardens. One of these charming, Tudor cottages belongs to the Sanyal family, where eight-year-old Uttara tussles with her brother, Prateek, 14, over riding the scooty she got on her birthday last month. Her home isn't made of chocolate cookies or lip-smacking toffee, yet it is a fairytale haven. This is where she got a new family when she was only 11 months old.

When she was five, Uttara's mother Nina, 42, and father, Chanchal, 41, told her the truth through mythological stories like that of Lord Krishna. The only legacy Uttara carries of her unknown family is the face she sees in the mirror. But that never made much of a difference to the Sanyals. As far as filmmaker Chanchal was concerned, Uttara completed the family, and Prateek found a partner

THE NEW CRADLE: (left to right) Uttara, Nina, Chanchal and Prateek Sanyal

in crime. With over 2.5 crore orphaned children in India and only 300 licensed NGOs finding homes for them, each adoption makes a difference. Central Adoption Resource Agency estimates that the number of adoptions within the country is gradually rising, from 2,150 in 2003 to 2,450 in 2006 due to simpler procedures. The Sanyals were able to bring Uttara home within nine months of submitting the papers. Today, as they sit in Uttara's room playing noughts and crosses, there is no indication that she is adopted. With a music band named Pink, Barbie dolls on her bedside, and a house filled with happy memories, Uttara is as much at home as she could've been anywhere.

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CHILDREN WERE ADOPTED
BY NRIs AND PEOPLE
OF FOREIGN ORIGIN IN 2006